

Finance Committee Meeting September 3rd 2025

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=IVyLWT-p99Y
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Municipal Meeting Summary: Finance Committee of Monty City Council

1. Pre-Meeting Hearings & Committee Work Sessions

(Omitted as no separate pre-meeting public hearing or committee session was held immediately prior to calling the regular meeting to order.)

2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** Presiding officer called the first meeting of the Finance Committee of the Monty City Council to order. Opening housekeeping noted that the working sessions are held strictly to gather and process detailed information by questioning department heads regarding their 2026 proposed budgets. No decisions, amendments to the budget ordinance, or formal actions would be taken, and no public comment would be taken during this meeting.
- **Attendance:**
 - Members Present: Mintosh, Green, Zen, Mason, and other committee members.
 - Presiding Officer: Noted as the Chair / Chairwoman of the Finance Committee.

3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** The meeting opened with members standing to face the flag and reciting the Pledge of Allegiance.
 - **Approval of Minutes:** Not discussed during this transcript segment.
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4. Substantive Business & Board Action

00:02:17 City Court Budget Review

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Judge Amanda Dunik (Municipal City Court).
- **Deliberation Summary:** Judge Dunik reported minimal changes to her budget, incorporating salary figures provided by the controller's office (reflecting a 4% increase) and reducing training fees and travel by \$400. Other insurance was adjusted to \$2,700 to break even on a line item currently in the red. Software maintenance remains flat (covering Jim Fluke and BIS digital recording system). Substantial discussion centered on "other services and charges," specifically copy machine fees (billed quarterly per copy) and psychological evaluations (psyche vows). Dunik noted rising costs for competency and insanity defense evaluations (\$1,500 to \$3,000 per case), though she hopes county-level discussions with community health partners might eventually provide free evaluations. Interpreter costs utilize Andrea Johnson from the Victim's Advocate office, who is highly trusted, translates court documents into Spanish, and charges less than state-licensed interpreters. Committee members also questioned the transition of all court staff (including three secretaries, court reporter, bailiff, probation officer, and public defender) back into the city general fund after adult probation user fees were entirely drained mid-year. The public defender's caseload, meeting structure, and state funding eligibility limitations (which currently exclude city/town courts from circuit/superior court reimbursement statutes) were also reviewed at length.
- **Item-Specific Public Input:** None (Public comment was explicitly restricted during these working sessions).
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Information-only budget review; no action taken.

00:18:20 Animal Control Budget Review

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Josh Talby, Director of Monty Animal Care and Services.
- **Deliberation Summary:** Director Talby presented the department's straightforward budget, incorporating 4% increases for full-time employees and modest reductions in natural gas (\$3K) and other services (\$4K). Increases were added to institutional medical (\$10K) and food/litter (\$10K). Committee members questioned apparent discrepancies in salary percentage increases (noting a higher percentage on paper due to 2025 adjustments) and heavily scrutinized the food/litter line item, which was 116% to 169%

depleted by July 1st. Talby explained that the shelter recently housed an unprecedented 420<U+2013>450 animals, costing approximately \$135<U+2013>\$145 per day to feed, and emphasized that as a municipal agency, they must accept all animals brought in by the police department. The veterinary line item is zero because it is consolidated into institutional/medical, which is subsidized by Petco grants. Staffing consists of 3 full-time Animal Control Officers (ACOs), a cat tech, a dog tech, an office manager, and roughly 21 part-time staff (totaling 26 employees). Overtime is driven by 24/7 operations and ACO staffing shortages. Talby also noted that the department services the entirety of the city plus unincorporated county areas (including several towns via interlocal agreement) and that county commissioners are aware of the need to replace a defunct transport van.

- **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Information-only budget review; no action taken.

00:34:18 Building Commissioner Budget Review

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Richard Rawlings, Building Commissioner.
- **Deliberation Summary:** Commissioner Rawlings stated his budget is straightforward, with salaried positions receiving a 4% raise as directed by the controller. Committee members again noted that actual salary figures reflected higher percentage increases than the adopted 4% benchmark across multiple department heads, prompting concerns about discrepancies between adopted salary ordinances and actual payroll figures. Discussion touched upon utility cost allocations based on square footage, clothing allowances for official staff identification on job sites, and building permit/inspection fee recoupment efforts. Rawlings noted that the department recently started taking trash and debris cases to court to secure cleanup orders, levy administrative fines, and collect sanitation fees. A part-time clerk position is maintained under part-time allocations.
- **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Information-only budget review; no action taken.

00:43:24 Human Rights Budget Review

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Miss Thompson, Director of Human Rights.
- **Deliberation Summary:** Director Thompson reported that the only increase in her department's budget is for salaries (reflecting a 4% structure, though facing similar accounting review regarding past adopted vs. paid figures). Thompson announced her upcoming retirement, noting that the board will decide whether to maintain the position's salary at her current level or reduce it for her successor. Committee members and leadership offered extensive accolades and emotional tributes thanking Thompson for her decades of dedicated community advocacy, partnership work with civil rights organizations (MLK Dream Team, NAACP, Indiana Black Expo, YWCA), and community-building initiatives. Training and travel fees were clarified as supporting board member professional development (ADA training) and community event partnerships.

- **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Information-only budget review; no action taken.

00:53:23 Police Department Budget Review

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Police Chief Sloan.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Chief Sloan reviewed the comprehensive police department budget, noting that a Local Income Tax (LIT) public safety budget figure of \$2,156,000 (missing due to a DLGF administrative snafu) was emailed to council members. The police department currently has 106 sworn officers out of a full-staff target of 108, though recent resignations highlight ongoing recruitment and retention challenges. Onboarding and training a new officer takes 16 to 18 months and involves expensive statutory psychological evaluations (\$1,000-\$1,200 per candidate). Overtime (\$421,000) remains high due to relentless demands for policing services, event security (such as the downtown "Fire Up" event costing ~\$10,000 in daily overtime), and council meeting security; Chief Sloan clarified that hiring more officers will not necessarily reduce overtime. The social work program grant has expired, requiring internal transfers from patrol lines to sustain the program while seeking long-term funding. Major software contracts like Axon drive substantial costs under other services and charges. Police merit and pension obligations are coordinated through the controller's office and state reimbursement funds.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Information-only budget review; no action taken.
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5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- No open public comment period or citizen forum was held during this working session. (Public input was restricted to designated upcoming public hearings and meetings).
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6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:**
 - Committee members requested that administration provide current budget performance reports, copies of past salary ordinances (specifically Ordinance 33-24), and minutes from prior adoption meetings to verify discrepancies between adopted salaries and actual payroll figures.
 - Upcoming public input opportunities regarding the 2026 budget were reiterated: a public hearing on September 8th, introduction during regular monthly meetings on September 8th, the final finance committee meeting on September 23rd, and final budget adoption on October 6th.

- **Adjournment:** A motion to adjourn was made and seconded, approved by voice vote, concluding the meeting.

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